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The true essence of religion lies not in preaching but in offering practical solutions to the community's problems.

BALBIR SINGH SEECHEWAL,
Environmental activist

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Kalam, who mentioned Seechewal's spiritual volunteerism in his speech on National Technology Day.

In 2006, after the Bein project was completed, Kalam visited Sultanpur Lodhi to see the environmental and economic spin-off of the rejuvenated Bein which solved the problem of water-logging in areas near its origin and led to a recharge of ground water in downstream areas, benefiting 100-odd villages. But Seechewal's mission is far from over. For the last three years, he has been leading a tirade against the discharge of untreated

sewage and industrial effluents from towns on the Bein's bank. Through sewa, he dug up ponds in 27 villages where sewage was being pumped into the water. "People have woken up to the menace of pollution but the authorities are still sleeping," he says. His efforts have met with partial success as the Government, forced by public outrage and Kalam's continued campaigning, installed a Rs 5 crore sewage treatment plant at Sultanpur Lodhi, feeding the treated water for irrigation in surrounding villages. "I prefer persuasion to confrontation," says Seechewal, who recently acquired a Rs 48-lakh heavy earth-mover for regular cleaning of the Bein bed. Most of his donors are NRIs from the area. "But the impact counts more than dollars," he says.

Now a regular speaker at seminars and conferences on environmental issues, Seechewal swears by his resolve to expand his campaign to rescue other polluted natural water sources of Punjab. Sutlej, also called a toxic trove by ecologists, is high on his list of rivers to be rescued. "The Bein is just the beginning. There is a lot to be done," says Punjab's homegrown eco-baba.